

Should Individuals Be Held Responsible for What They Believe?

Belief, Cowardice, and the Things We Refuse to Know

I do not trust people who say, too quickly, that belief is a choice.

It sounds brave. It sounds morally clean. But try it for five seconds. Decide, right now, that the ceiling above you is a lake. Decide that your left hand is older than the Roman Empire. Decide that the next stranger who walks past your window has been secretly appointed to judge your life. You can say these sentences. You can perform belief, badly, like a child pretending to be asleep. But you cannot simply believe them. Something in the mind resists command.

This is why blaming someone for a belief feels, at first, like blaming someone for a fever.

And yet I still think we should do it.

Not always. Not cheaply. Not with the smugness of someone who happened to be born downstream from better schools and better libraries. But yes: there are beliefs for which people should be held responsible. Not because they chose the belief the way one chooses a shirt, but because they chose the little arrangements that allowed the belief to survive. They chose the locked room. They chose the curtains. They chose not to answer when the knock came.

The question is not whether a belief first entered the mind voluntarily. Most do not. The question is what a person does once the belief starts to stink.

A child born into a closed religious community, a party-state, a racist family, or a sealed online subculture does not begin life in some bright neutral chamber, weighing propositions like a miniature philosopher. No one does. The first beliefs are absorbed like smells in a kitchen. You do not remember deciding that your mother's food smelled like home. You just grew into it. By the time you can name the smell, it has already trained your hunger.

So no, I do not want to blame people merely for inheriting a false picture of the world. That would be obscene. It would turn accident into guilt. A teenager raised on state television is not automatically wicked because the first political vocabulary he learns has already been poisoned. A child raised to distrust outsiders is not fully guilty before he has even learned that “outsider” is a word adults use to make fear sound reasonable.

But inheritance is not innocence forever.

At some point, a belief is no longer only received. It is guarded. It is fed. It is given excuses. The believer begins to do maintenance work.

This is the dirty little place where responsibility lives.

People do not all receive the same warnings, the same exits, or the same courage. Some meet contradiction early, in a classroom, in a book, in a friend who refuses to flatter them. Others meet it only as danger. Some never meet it clearly at all. But when contradiction does arrive clearly—when it stands there, awkward and breathing—then something changes.

A person may not be responsible for the first racist assumption he inherited. But when he has worked with the people his belief degrades, eaten beside them, watched them comfort their children, heard them speak intelligently, and still insists that they are lesser because the belief preserves his own importance, he is no longer merely repeating the past. He is polishing it.

A woman may not be responsible for stumbling into medical misinformation during a frightening illness. Fear makes people stupid. Pain makes people bargain. But when doctors explain, when evidence is shown, when the false cure harms someone else, and she still forwards the same video because it gives her the pleasure of being “awake” while others are “sheep”—what exactly are we supposed to call that? Confusion? Maybe at first. After a while, it becomes vanity with a bibliography.

There is a difference between being misled and making a home inside the misleading.

This distinction matters more now because ignorance has changed its texture. It is no longer only a lack. Sometimes ignorance is a lifestyle. It has playlists, newsletters, podcasts, private groups, recommended videos, soft lighting, and a comment section full of strangers calling you brave. A person can now arrange an entire world so that correction appears only in the form of an enemy. The old censor burned books. The new coward simply never clicks.

I know this in a smaller, less political way.

When I transferred schools, I had a breakdown before leaving and asked a close friend not to disappear from my life. I wanted our chat history to remain, almost ridiculously, as proof that I had passed through someone’s world. I was terrible at cutting ties. I believed that if

a friendship had been real enough, it should survive distance. Not perfectly, not every day, but somehow. I wanted a middle state between closeness and disappearance.

After we separated, the messages became fewer. She told me we were probably just friends for a stage of life, and that people did not need to keep sharing their lives with friends from the past. I understood the sentence rationally. I even knew, if I was honest, that there had always been gaps between us—differences we had stopped discussing because we had grown up together and did not want to ruin the familiarity. Still, I kept acting as if the friendship had not really ended. I sent updates sometimes. I liked her posts. I said hello when we met. I did all of this because I could not bear the idea that a person who had once mattered so much could become unreachable, as if the whole history had been deleted.

Then I heard that she was doing well at her new school. She had many friends, a new best friend, and I had become someone they talked about. Even now I do not think I had a clean right to accuse her. People move on. Affection changes its address. But I was furious, and then embarrassed by how furious I was. Only later did I understand that the collapse was not only about her. It was about a belief breaking. I had believed promises about friendship too literally. I had believed “forever” as if it were a structure, not a feeling people say when the feeling is still alive.

Her words and actions forced me to see something I did not want to know: that love and friendship are often more fluid than I had allowed them to be, and that sometimes a bond can be sacred to one person and seasonal to the other.

That experience made me less romantic about belief revision. Changing a belief is not like correcting a spelling mistake. Sometimes the belief has organized your memory. It has told you what certain years meant. When it breaks, the past has to be rearranged. So I understand why people resist correction. Even a small private truth can hurt this much; a political, religious, or moral truth can threaten an entire identity.

But pain explains avoidance. It does not make avoidance innocent.

This is where the modern excuse—“everyone is influenced by algorithms”—has become too comfortable. Of course algorithms matter. Of course they narrow attention, reward outrage, and learn our weaknesses faster than we do. But there is something childish about turning every adult with a phone into a helpless leaf in the machine. People are manipulated, yes. They are also often grateful for the manipulation. It saves them from the labor of changing.

Imagine someone lying in bed at 1:17 a.m., phone above his face, one eye half closed, thumb moving with the laziness of a bored king. He watches a video claiming that some hated group secretly controls everything. The first time, he laughs. The second time, he pauses. The third time, he sends it to a friend with “lowkey true?” The friend replies with a long article

explaining why it is false. He does not read it. Too long. Too annoying. Too obviously written by the kind of people who would deny it. The next night, the videos come faster.

Where, exactly, did responsibility begin? Not at the first video. Not even at the first flicker of suspicion. Maybe it began at the unread article. Maybe at the little thrill he felt when dismissing it. Maybe at the moment he realized the falsehood made him feel superior and decided, silently, not to disturb it.

No court could measure that moment. Still, we know it exists.

Real inquiry often begins in discomfort. Not the clean discomfort of a debate tournament, where everyone shakes hands afterward, but the uglier kind: the article you do not want to open, the friend whose criticism feels like betrayal, the evidence that makes your old loyalty look foolish. We do not naturally love truth. We love relief. We love the moment when a belief settles everything and the mind can stop pacing.

The responsible person is not the one who enjoys being corrected. Nobody enjoys it. Correction often feels like humiliation wearing a clean shirt. The responsible person is the one who can stand the itch a little longer.

This is why I do not think “belief is involuntary” settles anything. Yes, belief is not directly chosen. But attention is partly chosen. Company is partly chosen. Sources are partly chosen. Repetition is partly chosen. The mind has furniture, and we move more of it than we admit.

Belief is not harmless just because it is internal. It leaks. It enters votes, jokes, hiring decisions, family dinners, police reports, school boards, border policies. A private belief is often just a public act waiting for permission.

Still, responsibility must lower its voice when it meets terror.

If changing your belief means losing your job, your family, your safety, or your life, then the word “responsibility” cannot sound the same. A person under a dictatorship, surrounded by informants, fed on propaganda, threatened for doubt, is not in the same moral position as someone browsing counterarguments from a couch. Yes, there are dissidents. Yes, some people resist under impossible conditions. But I refuse to build ordinary responsibility on the expectation of sainthood.

Heroism is beautiful. It is not the minimum entrance fee for innocence.

This is where many historical judgments become too easy. We love saying, from a safe distance, that we would have seen through the lie. We would have opposed the regime. We would have hidden the persecuted. We would have read the banned book. Perhaps. Or perhaps we would have been tired, frightened, loyal to our parents, worried about our younger brother, careful with our words. Perhaps we would have learned not to notice.

Under pressure, people bend. Sometimes the bending is understandable. Sometimes it becomes collaboration. The line is not drawn with a ruler.

But some cases are not so murky.

Take slaveholders in nineteenth-century America. I have little patience for the phrase “men of their time” when the time itself contained abolitionists, rebellions, testimonies, pamphlets, sermons, lawsuits, and the visible fact of human suffering. They were not sealed inside ignorance. Many had to step over evidence every day. The enslaved person was not an abstract counterargument. He was in the room.

To continue believing in the justice of slavery under those conditions required more than passive inheritance. It required discipline. A narrowing of sight. A trained stupidity. The sort of stupidity that protects money.

That is responsibility.

Not because every slaveholder possessed perfect philosophical freedom. Not because social formation meant nothing. But because the correction was not hidden. It was inconvenient. There is a difference.

I am less interested in beliefs that are merely false than in beliefs that have learned how to survive their own exposure. Those are the dangerous ones. They develop shells. They call evidence biased. They call witnesses corrupt. They call compassion weakness. They call doubt betrayal. And the believer, after enough practice, begins to mistake this immune system for intelligence.

Some people do not reject truth dramatically. They simply fail to stop and think. They speak in ready-made phrases. They let the language of the group do their seeing for them. That kind of failure is quieter than fanaticism. It is also more common.

But thoughtlessness should not become a luxury excuse. If no interruption ever comes, blame should be cautious. But once something does interrupt—someone’s pain, a contradiction, a fact that will not fit, a child asking an embarrassingly simple question—then continuing not to think becomes an act. Not a grand act. Not a cinematic act. A small act. The kind people commit all day.

Scrolling past can be an act.

Closing the tab can be an act.

Saying “I don’t want to get political” when the issue is someone else’s humanity can be an act.

Of course, there are limits. I am not asking people to investigate every belief they possess. That would be madness. Nobody has the time, education, or emotional stamina to put the entire mind on trial. Some beliefs are trivial. Some errors are harmless. If someone believes a folk remedy cures hiccups, I do not care. Let them stand upside down and drink water from the wrong side of the glass.

Responsibility sharpens when the belief touches other people.

That is the test I trust more than abstract reasoning. Does the belief excuse harm? Does it make a group easier to despise? Does it let the believer keep an advantage? Has someone challenged it? Has the believer refused to look because looking would cost comfort?

Then blame may enter.

Not always with shouting. Sometimes with a cold clarity.

I do not want a world where people are punished for every inherited falsehood. That world would be merciless. But I also do not want a world where “I was raised this way” becomes a permanent shelter for cruelty. At some point the adult must answer for the child he keeps obeying.

Maybe that is the real scandal: not that people believe false things, but that they come to love the benefits of those false things. The belief gives them status, purity, belonging, innocence, revenge. It explains away failure. It identifies enemies. It turns confusion into a story. Truth, by comparison, is often rude. It arrives late, asks for documents, ruins the mood.

So should individuals be held responsible for what they believe?

Only when the belief has had a chance to meet resistance.

But when it has—when the evidence has appeared, when the suffering is visible, when the counterargument has been offered, when the believer feels that first unpleasant pressure and chooses the old comfort anyway—then yes. Hold them responsible. Not for being born into darkness. For drawing the curtains at noon.

I keep thinking of that student in bed, blue light on his face, the article still unopened beneath a stack of videos that tell him he is brave for not reading it. Maybe he is tired. Maybe he is lonely. Maybe the article is badly written. Maybe tomorrow he will open it.

Or maybe he will swipe it away again, and feel, for one clean second, relief.